Energy-Based Recurrent Transformers for Efficient Sequence Modeling

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Abstract

Transformers model sequences effectively, but full attention requires a growing key/value cache during autoregressive inference. Recurrent models compress past observations into a fixed-size state, creating a tradeoff between memory efficiency and information retention. This project will investigate an energy-based recurrent Transformer that represents memory through quadratic energy coefficients, together with a hybrid that combines this recurrence with local attention. I will compare full attention, local attention, pure energy recurrence, and the hybrid on byte-level language modeling and controlled associative recall. Experiments will match parameter counts and training data, repeat three random seeds, and measure prediction loss, recall accuracy, memory, and runtime. A separate time-matched comparison will examine whether any prediction advantage survives implementation overhead. The goal is to identify when recurrent energy memory is useful and where it fails through a reproducible, semester-scale study.

1. Introduction and Research Objectives

Sequence modeling supports applications such as language prediction and processing continuous text streams. The Transformer introduced attention as a central mechanism for modeling relationships between tokens [1]. Full causal attention retains representations of the preceding sequence; its attention computation and inference cache become more expensive as sequences grow. Recurrent formulations offer another approach: update a bounded state instead of storing every token. Linear attention demonstrates a connection between Transformer-style computation and recurrent networks [2]. Energy-based architectures additionally provide a way to describe memory and retrieval through an energy function [3].

My proposed model uses a recurrent quadratic memory with learned writing, forgetting, and reading. The hybrid repeats two energy blocks followed by one causal local-attention block. Recurrence can retain compressed information across the stream, while local attention preserves detailed nearby interactions. The project asks: **Does this combination provide a better tradeoff between predictive quality, memory usage, and computation than comparable attention-only models?**

Existing exploratory results motivate, but do not settle, this question. A three-seed CPU study of approximately 145,000-parameter models reported 2.512 test bits per byte for the hybrid versus 2.578 for full attention and 2.577 for local attention under equal steady-state update-time budgets [5]. However, a historical 10.6-million-parameter comparison favored full attention over pure energy at equal training bytes [6]. These protocols differ and cannot establish a scaling trend. I will reuse the implementation infrastructure while conducting fresh, explicitly controlled course experiments.

2. Methodology and Model

Research hypotheses. H1: The hybrid achieves lower held-out bits per byte than both attention controls at equal parameters and presented training bytes. H2: Energy recurrence and the hybrid maintain bounded carried inference state as prefix length increases. H3: The hybrid retains more information than local attention on queries whose supporting observations lie outside the local window. Each hypothesis may be rejected; reduced state alone does not establish better recall or faster execution.

Energy recurrence. For one attention head in transported slot coordinates, let A_t represent accumulated precision above a positive prior p_0, and S_t represent information stored in each slot. Learned projections produce keys k_t, values v_t, write strengths $w_t \geq 0$, and forgetting factors $f_t \in (0,1)$:

$$A_t = f_t \odot A_{t-1} + w_t k_t^2$$
$$S_t = f_t \odot S_{t-1} + w_t k_t v_t^T, \; P_t = p_0 + A_t$$

The memory energy is

$$E_t(M) = \tfrac{1}{2} \sum_j P_{t,j} ||M_j||^2 - \sum_j S_{t,j}^T M_j$$

Its unique minimum is $M^*_{t,j} = S_{t,j}/P_{t,j}$. Learned queries read this memory, with the implementation's two query reads combined to produce the block output. Residual connections, normalization, and feedforward layers complete the model. Model weights are trained through backpropagation using next-byte cross-entropy. The contribution is a controlled study of this recurrent memory formulation and its hybrid layout, rather than a claim to reproduce the distinct architecture in [3].

Models and data. The core comparison contains four families: full causal attention; local attention with a 64-byte window; pure energy recurrence; and the two-energy/one-local hybrid. I will use a 256-byte vocabulary and the enwik8 corpus, which contains Wikipedia text and markup [4]. The first 90 million bytes will form training, the next 5 million validation, and the final 5 million test. I will record the corpus checksum and sample windows within split boundaries. Test evaluation will use fixed, nonoverlapping windows with a declared state-reset policy.

The planned grid uses approximately 145,000 and 1.05 million parameters, with three seeds per family: 24 main fits. Feedforward widths will adjust parameter counts to within 0.5% at each size. All models will receive paired minibatch streams, a 512-byte training context, the same effective batch size, AdamW, and the same learning-rate search allowance. A separate calibration seed will select among three peak learning rates using validation only. Profiling will fix one common presented-byte budget before main training. Repeated and unique training bytes will be recorded separately. If resources cannot support the full grid, I will retain all families and seeds at the smaller size.

Controlled recall and ablations. Separate associative-recall sequences will contain randomly generated key/value associations, distractors, and a final query. Train, validation, and test episodes will use separate random streams. Delays of 32, 64, 128, and 256 bytes will expose the local window's limits. Accuracy will be measured only at answer positions. Pure energy and attention controls provide the principal architecture ablations; a fixed-forgetting variant of the hybrid will test whether learned forgetting helps, if time permits.

3. Evaluation, Feasibility, and Expected Contribution

Evaluation. The primary language metric is held-out bits per byte, computed from next-byte cross-entropy. I will report each seed and the mean, paired differences, training curves, and uncertainty across fixed evaluation blocks. Recall accuracy will measure memory directly. Inference profiling will measure prefill and decode latency at prefixes of 512, 2,048, and 8,192 bytes, reporting batch size, precision, warmup, and timing variability. Full attention will use a preallocated cache. Carried state, peak training memory, and parameter memory will be reported separately. Evaluation beyond the training context will be labeled context extrapolation.

Data-matched training and time-matched training answer different questions. At the smaller size, an additional three-seed comparison will give each family an equal end-to-end time allowance that includes setup and evaluation. Learning-rate and checkpoint selection will use validation only; final test results will not guide subsequent changes. Numerical checks will cover causality, chunked versus token-by-token execution, nonfinite values, and checkpoint restart behavior.

Feasibility. The existing PyTorch implementation, checkpoints, and evaluation harness provide a working starting point. I will request available local or RIT GPU access and cap new GPU experiments at 12 hours: two for correctness/profiling, eight for training, and two for evaluation. Profiling will reserve a 20% timing margin when choosing the common training budget. CPU preparation precedes GPU work; if access is limited, the replicated 145,000-parameter study remains the minimum deliverable. The study will characterize small-model trends without extrapolating to foundation-model scale.

Individual work plan. I will conduct implementation, experiments, analysis, and writing, and arrange a classmate or another project group to proofread the proposal and final report.

Dates	Milestone and output
October 9	Submit proposal; define hypotheses, controls, and measurements.
October 10–16	Verify implementation, prepare initial profiles, and present the proposal on October 16.
October 17–November 1	Freeze data/protocol; complete learning-rate calibration and the first replicated comparison.
November 2–15	Complete the second size if feasible; run associative recall and the forgetting ablation.
November 16–29	Run time-matched confirmation and inference profiling; freeze selections and evaluate test data.
November 30–December 8	Analyze results, create figures, obtain peer feedback, and finish the report and reproducibility README.
December 9	Submit final report and code/artifacts as required.
December 10–13	Rehearse and give the final presentation on December 13.

Expected contribution. Deliverables will include documented code, frozen experiment specifications, checkpoints/logs, quality-versus-cost figures, and an analysis of recall failures. The study will identify where hybrid recurrence is useful and where attention remains preferable. Positive and negative results will both contribute to the final analysis.

References

1. Vaswani, A., et al. “Attention Is All You Need.” *NeurIPS*, 2017. Conference proceedings.

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3. Hoover, B., et al. “Energy Transformer.” *NeurIPS*, 2023. Conference proceedings.

4. Mahoney, M. “About the Test Data,” Large Text Compression Benchmark. Dataset source and checksums.

5. EnergyTransformer project. “Compute-Controlled Confirmation.” Existing local exploratory report, September 2026. Local report (included in project repository).

6. EnergyTransformer project. “Reconciled Evidence and Repair Results.” Existing local historical-results audit, September 2026. Local report (included in project repository).